Nietzsche

No philosopher has had a greater influence on the twentieth century than Friedrich Nietzsche. He was a remarkably original thinker who extrapolated major tendencies of late nineteenth-century Western thought and drew extreme, disturbing conclusions from his analysis of its history. His position on religion and theology is in many respects the inverse of Søren Kierkegaard's.

Nietzsche is often regarded as a seminal precursor of existentialism, but he chose the other half of the Kierkegaardian alternative. Rather than abandoning everything to religion, he abandoned religion in favour of the tradition of pagan Greco-Roman antiquity. He was an extraordinarily important thinker in the undermining of theology and in changing the path of Western religion.

There are figures in Western history with whom we might compare him, but few as radical. In some respects he resembles Machiavelli because he is strictly amoral. He regards morality as an impediment to superior people and the superior activities they might undertake. He seems incapable of pity, like Callicles in Plato's *Gorgias*. He wants power.

Power is central to Nietzsche's conception of the world. When we lose theological orientation and are marooned in the world of space and time, there are only greater and lesser quantities of power: greater and lesser capacities to do what lies within the human domain.

Nietzsche seeks to provoke an atheistic heroism that replaces religion with art. These philosophical problems will be influential in Joyce's development of an aesthetic philosophy when he breaks away from religion and intends to substitute art for it. Nietzsche is often criticized, and sometimes praised, as a source of twentieth-century atheism and existentialism. He has also been associated with Nazism, but that connection is difficult and requires caution. Representing him simply as a proto-Nazi is questionable.

He was a hypersensitive individual with extraordinary intellectual gifts, a professor of philology who acquired a tremendous command of classical languages early in life. He was appointed to a professorship at twenty-four. In the German-speaking academic world, with its prestigious disciplinary chairs, that was a remarkable achievement. People could not praise the young Nietzsche highly enough.

Besides being an exceptional scholar, he was ferociously honest. Like Kierkegaard, he did his best to be an individual and to sense tremors in the foundations of Western culture that others could not feel. He was like a seismograph, detecting continental shifts that would eventually produce an intellectual earthquake and a great conflagration.

He did not cause that earthquake any more than a seismograph causes one. His poetic sensitivity and extraordinarily extensive grasp of the Western tradition enabled him to see the implications of its development and the crisis it had entered after Darwin. In this

respect, Nietzsche is not the cause of the events he describes. He is the messenger: he delivers the message rather than creating it.

The message is: “God is dead. God remains dead. And we have killed him.” We should not blame Nietzsche for killing God. He is saying that Western culture has already killed God by the time he writes this in *The Gay Science*. The rise of modern natural science and the movement from mythological explanations toward a more sophisticated understanding of the world have brought about this death.

That sophistication is an advance in culture, but a danger to moral orientation. When God dies, our constructions of right and wrong, our conceptions of ethics and metaphysics, are thrown into question. All moral orientations must change radically. Nietzsche can also be compared to a canary in a coal mine, affected by poisonous gas before human beings are.

At the end of the nineteenth century, Nietzsche sings of the end of theology, which means the end of metaphysics and, in his account, the end of the tradition of Western philosophy. In works such as *Beyond Good and Evil*, *On the Genealogy of Morality*, and *The Antichrist*, he deliberately undermines faith in the Western religious tradition.

He also tries to redirect philosophy away from metaphysics toward this world. His goal is to make people live here and deprive them of the religious illusions that had sustained society. These are now hollow illusions. If illusions are needed, new ones must be created; the old ones no longer work.

This alone might not have attracted so much attention had Nietzsche not also been, in my judgment, the greatest prose poet of the German language. His poetic and philosophical gifts form a rare combination. Joined to a will to truth as fierce and tenacious as that of any philosopher, they produce volatile, dangerous results, much as in Kierkegaard. Nietzsche is at his best sharpening little daggers to throw at his reader.

Section 126 of *The Gay Science* says: “Mystical explanations are considered profound; the truth is that they are not even superficial.” I had to spend a great deal of time removing that sentence from my mind. It is one of philosophy’s greatest one-liners, devastating enough to make whole libraries of theology crumble beneath its force.

It is a sharp, pointed, barbed instrument of war. Nietzsche is at war with his readers. He accepts no compromise and demands that they take things seriously. Spiritually, he resembles Kierkegaard, but as Kierkegaard’s alter ego: he follows an idea all the way and refuses to compromise.

I suspect he would have appreciated Kierkegaard’s *Either/Or*, but chosen the other alternative. The same philosophical radicalism and spiritual ferocity motivate both men. Understanding the kind of writing Nietzsche practises makes him easier to read, particularly when we compare him with his great philosophical and intellectual opponent, Socrates.

Nietzsche hated Socrates, but respected him. Here, at last, was someone worth discussing and addressing. The problem with Socrates resembles the problem with Jesus: both generated a metaphysics that led Western culture beyond the world of space and time. The Socrates of Plato’s *Republic* presents the realm of Forms, where perfect

beauty and truth reside. Christianity offers heaven, with God, the Holy Spirit, saints, and martyrs.

For Nietzsche, the problem is not a particular dogma, but the whole idea of metaphysics. This world is the world; there is no other world to inhabit. We should no longer discuss Greek or Christian metaphysics, but adopt a new stance: love the earth, find what is best in this world, and improve and perfect human possibilities here and now. The influence on Joyce's aesthetic philosophy is apparent.

The comparison with Socrates goes deeper than professional jealousy, although there is much of that in Nietzsche's attacks. Socrates' characteristic way of communicating is irony. His speech is not remarkable for its literal meaning; it is persistently, sometimes opaquely, ironic. There are often several layers of irony, making it inexhaustible and explaining why we still read it twenty-five centuries later.

Nietzsche has developed a comparable device: not irony, but oxymoron. My argument is that he uses oxymoron as Socrates uses irony. An oxymoron is an expression such as "cold fire" or "hot ice," attributing to something a property opposite to the one it ordinarily possesses.

Nietzsche asks, in section 265 of *The Gay Science*: "What are humanity's truths, ultimately? They are its irrefutable errors." What could an irrefutable error be? The oxymoron suggests that Western rationalism has never brought us certainty or anything approaching the standards of Platonic knowledge. Without God or Plato's realm of Forms to validate knowledge, the best we can obtain is a series of perspectives on the world.

What we call truth becomes, in this reading, the errors we have not yet refuted. The drive toward knowledge inherited from Greece and Christianity is undermined and devalued. Nietzsche calls part of his programme the "revaluation of all values": changing the entire tablet of good and evil passed down through Western generations.

He intends to destroy that tablet and create a new one, replacing the Western religious tradition with his own thought. He also intends to abolish the philosophical tradition because he believes it requires metaphysics. Once metaphysics is removed, that tradition can no longer continue. He seriously and honestly thinks that Western philosophy and religion end with him.

That is no modest estimation of oneself. A man who refers to himself in print as the Antichrist may suggest that megalomania has entered the picture. There is some justice in that criticism. Yet he deals with the greatest philosophical problems and is a superior thinker with great intellectual merit and courage. Ignoring religion is easy; abolishing it is difficult. Indifference to religious questions and deciding to burn them all down are very different things.

He is not a prosaic writer, and no one reads him without being affected. When I first read the passage on God's death in *The Gay Science*, I had to read it repeatedly. It was among the most difficult passages I encountered at university, and I have never completely made my peace with it. It rewards close reading.

Always keep oxymoron in mind. Rather than trying to extract an ordinary logical meaning from "irrefutable errors," recognize Nietzsche's characteristic device. It gives

readers something provocative to think about without committing him to a definite logical position. Exactly what he believes is not easy to assemble. Like many philosophers, he is better at attacking what he dislikes than defending what he approves.

He claims that ethics, previously founded upon Christianity or metaphysical philosophy, is over: the traditions of right and wrong transmitted through fifteen, twenty, or twenty-five centuries are gone. Ethics becomes an "irrefutable error," although he seems to work very hard to refute it. In this account, Nietzsche thinks philosophy is over and writes primarily as a poet rather than a logician. He does not mind contradiction. An oxymoron is itself a contradictory utterance.

"Hot ice" and "cold fire" do not make literal sense, but move us poetically rather than logically. This is what Nietzsche does well. In attacking morality and ethics, he adopts a position resembling Raskolnikov's in Dostoevsky's *Crime and Punishment*.

Before Raskolnikov returns to the Christian fold, he commits murder because he has a theory of the exceptional man. Moral norms that we expect to be universal do not, in his theory, apply to certain superior individuals. Nietzsche makes a related argument: great world-historical individuals need not be bound by traditional constraints of right and wrong. They are great artists and creators.

"Artist" does not mean only painter or literary writer. Creativity can appear in politics, science, or any other field. Superior individuals who break inherited forms are artists in this sense. The artist is the creative human being, and creation need not take the form of sculpture or literature.

For Nietzsche, this artistic capacity is more important than a moral judgment about the artist. A person may be wicked, but if he writes brilliantly, he is a superior individual. Obedience to the usual rules imposed on everyone is not what makes him great. Greatness requires a willingness to abandon what Nietzsche calls "herd morality."

He regards moral systems as serving the needs of the lowest common denominator. Christianity, in his reading, was a religion of slaves because it served slaves' interests. A Roman master, with whom Nietzsche sympathizes, could act cruelly without feeling bad about it. He did not suffer from the religious guilt that inhibits the superior heroic person.

Nietzsche thinks Christianity poisoned Western heroism by giving superior people a conscience and restricting their capacity to act. Who knows what great figures might have accomplished without those arbitrary Christian constraints? His complaint about Pascal is revealing: Christianity, in his view, ruined a superior man by turning his mind against his own rational abilities.

Blaise Pascal was a great mathematician and scientist who suffered over religious questions. The argument amounts to preferring one more Pascal to a million Christians anticipating salvation, and wishing to free him from Christian myths so that he could become the heroic person he might have been.

Nietzsche has a grievance against the entire Christian tradition. He thinks it inhibits individuality and heroism, and heroism is his central concern. In this portrayal, he has

little interest in humanity's mass, which he regards as without value; only superior individuals count.

I strongly suspect that he considered himself one of them. Whenever someone argues for a philosophical aristocracy, that person usually imagines himself an aristocrat. We do not see plebeians advocating such an aristocracy. Those defending elitism think they belong to the elite. Nietzsche would not be embarrassed by that. He rejects the Christian equality of souls: without God, there is no God before whom all can be equal.

The big fish eat the small fish. Some people are better and more capable than others; we inhabit nature. His position is, in effect, to stop equalizing conditions and supporting the weak, and instead help great people do great things, leaving the rest of humanity aside. This is radical and courageous, but also profoundly immoral.

His immorality has something of the grandeur of Milton's Satan. He will not serve. There is something strangely attractive in that refusal. He sometimes offers repulsive ideas, yet I cannot rid myself of a certain admiration. I would not become his follower.

Indeed, simply following Nietzsche would not be Nietzschean. His instruction is, in effect: be an individual; do not follow me. I have found my path; find yours. Anyone who reads all his books and believes everything he says has understood nothing. The point is to think these problems through for oneself.

Like Kierkegaard, he forces us to become individuals. I regard this as a useful, necessary tonic, but would be concerned if someone concluded that almost everything was correct. Perhaps it is; perhaps it is not. What matters is that it stimulates and provokes, offering questions even when it cannot offer satisfactory answers.

In *On the Uses and Disadvantages of History for Life*, he presents a conception of human existence and its value that is surprisingly unflattering. He lives in Darwin's age. *On the Origin of Species* has appeared, causing a tremendous stir. Some try to reconcile Darwin with Christianity; others suggest that we can accept Darwin without a fundamental change, retaining Christianity's essence while abandoning a few myths.

The position attributed to Nietzsche here rejects that compromise. Darwin has fundamentally changed our understanding of ourselves: human beings belong to nature. We cannot simply return to a providential account of humanity beginning with Adam and Eve in Eden. We are complicated apes, and our history must be rewritten.

The future universal historian will not begin in Babylon, Egypt, or the Garden of Eden, but with something like pond scum, the green single-celled life of stagnant water. Humanity is a highly complicated development of such life. Our difference is that we have acquired the bizarre idea that the universe revolves around us. In this provocative picture, we are complicated and arrogant pond scum, misunderstanding the nature of the world.

After Darwin, there is no return. God is dead, though people have not understood it. If we are such natural beings, how can we find value? We must choose and act. Without ancient religious myths, what directs us? Even pond scum has to do something. Nietzsche's answer is the will to power.

He thinks he has found a natural motive in all living things. This is, for him, a biological interpretation: organisms reproduce, occupy territory, and compete with other species because organic life is motivated by the will to power. In complex beings such as humans, it is sublimated, twisted, and distorted, but it still moves us to act.

A general conquers a city: will to power. A scientist discovers a phenomenon: will to power. A saint fasts, mortifies the flesh, and disciplines the senses: also will to power. It can be directed outward, but also imposed on oneself. It becomes a master key to human motivation once we recognize ourselves as complicated animals, natural beings among other natural beings.

This leads to the relationship between Christianity and science, a persistent problem that becomes especially pressing for modern thinkers. Nietzsche offers a peculiar perspective: their antagonism is comparatively late, and modern natural science is an intellectual product of Christianity. Its roots lie within biblical religion.

Genesis 1:26–28 grants human beings dominion over birds, beasts, and fish. In this interpretation, God tells us to make nature serve our purposes. That is not intuitive to every religious tradition. A Buddhist might ask why we wish to dominate nature rather than harmonize ourselves with it. The desire to push nature around is not intrinsic to humanity; it is one inheritance of biblical religion.

It takes centuries for this intellectual inheritance to develop. When dominion over the earth is realized through modern natural science, something deeply ironic occurs. Truth does not set us free; it brings us into bondage to nature. We hoped that investigation would reveal a sign of God's plan, his hand in the design of natural patterns.

Once we reach Darwin, however, this account finds only a vast, blind, contingent mechanism. Natural selection is not evidence of divine design but the way events work out. Teleology is lost: nature no longer supplies a purpose, and we are no longer what we believed ourselves to be.

Here we enter the contemporary world. I would suggest that Nietzsche is one of our first contemporaries, because our world is saturated with these themes. This is the end of humanity's *Sonderstellung*, its special position. We once distinguished God's creation—trees, insects, fish, and birds—from people, endowed with a divine spark and made in God's image.

That special status gave human beings a value different from that of a codfish or an elk. Human beings possessed bodies and souls. Nietzsche rejects it: without God, we cannot be made in God's image. The provocative alternative is that we are highly complicated pond scum, without a divinely assigned purpose. Supposed discoveries of such a purpose are, in this reading, imaginative projections.

Nor can nature provide the old consolation. It is a vast, booming, buzzing confusion. Even Hume allowed some limited force to the argument from design. Nietzsche rejects design, teleology, and purpose. Section 125 of *The Gay Science*, in which the madman announces God's death, asks whether we are falling in every direction and who gave us the sponge to wipe away the horizon. Wiping away the horizon is a beautiful image of lost orientation.

Without a cosmic orientation or an authoritative distinction between good and evil, we are left with multiple perspectives. They need not fit together, and no single divine viewpoint judges true and false, accurate and inaccurate. There is a wilderness of mirrors, a series of perspectives, equally arbitrary in the account offered here.

Hegel spoke of the night in which all cows are black. I would say that Nietzsche has turned out the lights: the cows and everything else are black. He refuses responsibility for causing this. To accuse or refute him as though he had killed God misses his point. He is not a titan. Western culture killed God through the Faustian connection between Christianity and science.

The will to truth and the will to dominate nature helped Christianity support modern science. Inquiry continued until Darwin made humanity conclusively part of nature. Our special position disappeared. We become no more cosmically important than birds, fish, or pond scum. Whatever value we have must be created, not revealed from above. The best available heroism creates a domain of value instead of inheriting it.

These are contemporary, existential themes. Once we reach this condition, Nietzsche believes, we cannot go back. Religion is dead permanently. “God remains dead” means that he will not rise on the third day, the thirtieth day, or ever. We are left here, and Nietzsche should not be blamed for reporting the circumstances.

Christianity resembles a snake eating its own tail. It generated science, and science attacked Christianity. But, after eliminating Christianity, science undermines the will to truth and the dominion over nature that had supplied its own impetus. Science abolishes religion and metaphysics and starts undermining itself.

For Nietzsche, eliminating metaphysics also threatens truth. If truth is a metaphysical concept, and science eliminates metaphysics, what truth remains for science to discover? It is night, and all cows are black. Western culture implodes. Nietzsche draws out the consequences of the Darwinian revolution, facing something most people cannot bear to contemplate.

Section 125 gives us the madman walking through a city in daylight with a lighted lantern. Others do not realize that it is now night, figuratively speaking. The scene also recalls Diogenes the Cynic, who carried a lamp by day while searching for an honest human being. That search, apparently unsuccessful, is itself a kind of madness. Nietzsche’s version is poetic and poignant.

The madman is not looking for an honest person, but for God. People jeer and laugh. Has God left town? Is he hiding? Where has he gone? They regard the search as foolish. The madman declares that they have killed God, then throws down his lantern and says that he has come too early. They have not yet realized what they have done.

They treat God’s death as amusing, although, in this interpretation, it is the greatest catastrophe in world history. Sooner or later, they will understand, but they are not equal to the task. How can they bear the responsibility? The madman enters churches and sings his *Requiem aeternam deo,* a requiem for God. He calls the churches God’s tombs and monuments.

The stone rolled away for Jesus will not be rolled away again. People still attend these tombs of religion every Sunday. The madman seems insane, but he is the first to

recognize the momentous situation. This is among the most moving and important passages in Nietzsche.

Nietzsche is unsystematic, moving from theme to theme without developing any one completely. His vignettes, however, are carefully calculated to wound. They are supposed to hurt us mentally and intellectually. He is at war with his readers, driving us from complacency.

He also seeks something new. The way out is not Kierkegaard's leap of faith: in Nietzsche's account, the leap is hopeless, because there is nothing to land on. His alternative is the *Übermensch*, translated as "overman" or "superman." Because the latter evokes Clark Kent, I prefer the German word. The *Übermensch* would rise above ordinary humanity.

The relation of this figure to ordinary human beings would resemble ours to the great apes. In the extreme interpretation proposed here, killing a human being—or a million—would impose no moral constraint on such a figure, just as killing an animal is not ordinarily treated as equivalent to killing a person. This is a conception of superiority without moral limitations.

Nietzsche looks to Western heroism, to Homer, whom he greatly admired, and Shakespeare's tragic heroes. Such figures live on the appropriate scale. If sanctification and blessedness are no longer possible, perhaps we can create a domain of value in this world.

Creating value becomes a titanic aesthetic task. Writing poems is comparatively minor beside creating tablets of good and evil capable of sustaining a culture for twenty, thirty, or fifty centuries. This ambition approaches—and, in my judgment, crosses—the line into megalomania.

That megalomania is partly the product of his Promethean stance. Nietzsche is the inverse of Job, a new Prometheus shaking his fist at God. He will not serve. As a Miltonic, satanic figure, he refuses service and seeks to help produce the *Übermensch*, an improvement upon the inferior, incapable people he sees around him. Perhaps then human life could acquire a purpose, a new teleology.

The end of metaphysics and the rise of the *Übermensch* are intimidating and moving. Nietzsche's work impresses and repels at the same time. Besides criticizing religion and philosophy and offering a future programme, he attacks almost everything in the surrounding culture.

He connects things with Christianity that we might not initially connect. If the relation between science and Christianity is plausible, perhaps some further connections also merit consideration. He regards socialism, feminism, democracy, and Romanticism as products of excessive Christian pity and sentimentality. He rejects socialism because, in his view, it helps the weak and harms the strong. He has no interest in pity as a political principle.

The account offered here reads his hostility to feminism in similarly harsh terms: strong men are permitted to dominate women, whom he treats as inferior. He is a radical aristocrat, uninterested in democratizing humanity or assisting those he regards as intrinsically inferior.

Christianity contributed to equality in Western political thought through the idea that all souls were equal before God: all were sinners, none justified by themselves. What happens when God is removed? Nietzsche denies that all souls can be made equal. Some are greater than others. Goethe is not equivalent to the peasants around him; Beethoven and the great artists, religious leaders, and philosophers are superior individuals.

Yet past superiority is insufficient for the present. A new kind and degree of superiority must carry us through the emerging age of nihilism. Nietzsche proposes to help by writing *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*, which, in this interpretation, he seriously intends to supersede the Bible.

It sounds extraordinary that a late nineteenth-century man should undertake to displace Jesus in Western culture. Yet he believes his book can provide a new scripture and an affirming, anti-metaphysical stance. Zarathustra tells readers to love the earth and this world, and stop constructing unreal metaphysical realms. Nietzsche seeks to fill the gap left by Western culture's collapse. Here megalomania reaches its greatest extent.

There are resonances with Hegel's philosophical ambition. Hegel thought he possessed something like an omniscient master key to philosophical problems; Nietzsche thinks he has abolished them. The effect is similar: each understands something that the rest of us intellectual dwarfs supposedly cannot absorb.

Nietzsche forces us toward art, religion, and philosophy as the greatest human achievements, but religion is over and the religious part of philosophy, metaphysics, has also ended. Only a fragment of the old philosophy remains. What still has power and seriousness is art. It becomes a domain not of transcendence, but of salvation: secular, earthly salvation. Stephen Dedalus will take this path.

Nietzsche is, in my judgment, among the greatest and most important modern thinkers about theology. When he abolishes religion and truncates philosophy, art and the artist acquire supreme importance. It is therefore ironic that a thinker who emphasizes aesthetics, and whom I regard as the greatest German prose poet, seems unable to judge his own verse. Perhaps God is waiting in the wings, laughing at him.

The Gay Science has a rhymed prelude and, in its expanded edition, an appendix of songs. I find the verse extraordinarily bad, among the worst German doggerel. It is difficult to understand how he could place it beside such magnificent prose poetry. Constructing an aesthetic theory and producing aesthetically successful writing are different accomplishments. His poetic prose does not make his verse equally successful.

I have heard him described as an intellectual dandy. He is no more a dandy than I am. His verse gives the impression of a frustrated invalid trying to act heroically rather than an actually heroic individual. He is a hero of the soul or spirit, rather than of his practical career. His life ended in severe incapacity. After his mental collapse, he died in Weimar in 1900. The cause of his long illness remains disputed; syphilis cannot be stated as an established fact.

I am an enthusiast of autobiography, one of literature's most interesting genres, and Nietzsche's certainly catches the eye. Its title is *Ecce Homo*, "Behold the man," the phrase Pilate uses when presenting Jesus before the crucifixion. Choosing it for an autobiography suggests no small degree of megalomania.

Four principal chapter titles take the form of questions: “Why I Am So Wise,” “Why I Am So Clever,” “Why I Write Such Good Books,” and “Why I Am a Destiny.” These are the matters Nietzsche regards as worth telling us about himself, which may reveal more than he intended. His philosophical aspiration and ambition are off the scale.

It is easy to satirize the excesses of this autobiography. Calling it “Behold the man” seems to offer a choice between himself and Jesus and expect us to choose Nietzsche. It suggests that he has lost touch with the rest of the world. Yet I would approach the four questions from another direction and propose answers that might help us understand him.

Why is he so clever? Because he is the great poet-philosopher of the modern age, combining poetry and philosophy with an intensity scarcely seen since Plato. His attacks on Plato resemble Plato’s attacks on Homer: professional jealousy. The predecessor is too good and has exerted influence in the wrong direction. Nietzsche’s cleverness is that of a great poet-philosopher.

Why is he so wise? I am less convinced of his wisdom than I once was. Perhaps he is seriously mistaken. Nevertheless, to give the devil his due, if he is wise, his wisdom lies in seeing the implications of God’s death: Western culture has killed God, and we must confront that fact.

Why does he write such good books? He has mastered oxymoron, the modern analogue of Socratic irony. It is a master key to his writing. When reading the paradoxical passages, remember that oxymoron is not the problem but the solution. It permits an appreciation of Nietzsche that need not drive the reader as nearly mad as it once drove me.

Why is he a destiny? I believe it is because he was willing to confront squarely the implications of modern natural science. The physical world of space and time is real, whether we like it or not. We must make our moral intuitions and religious commitments consistent with the best of our rational activity. Abandoning responsibility to our rational faculties is ultimately doomed to failure.

Darwin is real, and natural selection offers our best understanding of the biological history of the world. Science is here to stay. In the argument developed here, Nietzsche makes us face the demand to bring science and religion into a form we can live with. If one must be sacrificed, that is a possibility, but science presents a challenge to Western religion that cannot be met by minor repairs.

A radical either-or choice is required, and Nietzsche forces it upon us. Had he not done so, someone else would have. For this reason, I think he is right to regard himself as a destiny: the West is destined to confront its own rational capacities.